have been impossible for us to hold North Persia as long as an unfriendly and uncivilised Russian Government is in existence, but South Persia ought certainly not to be thrown away without an effort.[43]

Although it begs the question as to when was there ever a Russian government that would have been happy to see a British hold on north Persia, Churchill's statement appears logical. After all, it was in the south of Persia that British interests had traditionally been centred prior to the First World War. Protection of, and access to, the oilfields in the south was of vital importance to the British Navy, as the Admiralty had reminded the Foreign Office in December 1920.[44] W.A. Smart, the Oriental Secretary of the British Legation in Tehran, also advocated a shift in focus towards the south. Writing in June 1921, Smart argued that by that point the north of Persia had become so infested with Bolshevik agents that the British Legation simply did not have the resources to counter them. Smart believed the British government should be realistic regarding the Persian situation, and retreat south to make its stand against the Bolsheviks.[45] In Armitage-Smith's words: 'Let the North have its taste of Bolshevik rule; let the experiment of reconstruction be tried in the...South.'[46]

Curzon, however, was opposed to the 'southern policy'. In a telegram to Norman the foreign secretary asked (rhetorically) whether 'damage to our prestige, of which you complain, only be enhanced by a precipitate retreat and abandonment of whole of Northern Persia to an enemy, whose advance is by no means certain, and a revolution which can probably still be avoided [?]'.[47] Perhaps surprisingly, the Indian government agreed with the foreign secretary in regards to the southern policy, albeit for different reasons. Although Delhi's interests in Persia certainly lay in the south, in Chelmsford's opinion, having 'a Soviet Government in the north, and a Shah Government, supported or dominated by Britain, in the south', would have an equally bad, if not worse effect on India as Britain's current Persian policy.[48] The Indian government welcomed the removal of British troops because it saw it as a step back from Persian internal affairs; what it did not want was for Britain to simply turn its attention from the north to the south of that country. It had been just such an attempt to carve up Persia into